

Three-Day Kyoto Itinerary for June 2026

Kyoto's blend of centuries-old temples, tranquil pockets of nature and delicious local food is well suited to travellers who prefer depth over speed. A three-day visit in June (rainy season) can be wonderfully relaxing if you cluster sights by area and include quieter neighbourhoods. Below is a suggested itinerary that balances famous landmarks with serene escapes and local culinary experiences.

Day 1 – Northern Higashiyama & Old Town Streets

Morning

- **Honen-in Temple** – Start early on the **Philosopher's Path**. Honen-in is a favourite among locals; the approach leads through a moss-covered gate, past two sand mounds (said to purify visitors) and over a stone bridge into a hidden grotto ¹. The temple is free, usually uncrowded and surrounded by tall maples. Take your time to enjoy the calm.
- **Honen-in to Ginkaku-ji** – From Honen-in it's a short walk to **Ginkaku-ji (Silver Pavilion)**. While popular, arriving at opening time minimises crowds. The dry-sand "Sea of Silver Sand" garden and moss-covered grounds are peaceful in the morning light.
- **Stroll the Philosopher's Path** – Continue south along the canal. The path is lined with hydrangeas in June. Pop into smaller temples like **Shisen-do**, a hermit's retreat hidden in a residential area. Shisen-do has a dry gravel garden bordered by azaleas that bloom in spring ². Another option is **Nanzen-ji's Tenju-an** sub-temple, known for its pond garden; or **Murin-an Villa**, a Meiji-era villa with a quiet garden ³.

Lunch

- **Obanzai or Shojin-ryori** – Kyoto's local cuisine emphasises seasonal vegetables, tofu and delicate flavours. Obanzai refers to home-style small dishes made from fresh produce and dashi ⁴. A good place to try it near the Philosopher's Path is **Okutan Nanzenji** or **Tenryu-ji Shigetsu**. Shojin-ryori (Buddhist vegetarian cuisine) is another option; it uses Kyoto vegetables and tofu without meat ⁵.

Afternoon

- **Gion & Ninen-zaka** – Take the bus to **Kiyomizu-dera**. The temple's 13 m-high wooden veranda offers sweeping views of Kyoto ⁶. Don't rush; wander through the historic lanes of **Sannenzaka** and **Ninen-zaka** where traditional machiya houses host craft shops and tea houses. Drink from the Otowa waterfall at Kiyomizu for luck ⁶ and stop at **Jishu-jinja** shrine on the temple grounds for a playful ritual of love.

Evening

- **Pontocho or Gion dinner** – Enjoy dinner in a **Kyo-kaiseki** restaurant (a multi-course meal that showcases Kyoto's seasonal ingredients ⁷) or a smaller izakaya. In Gion, consider a matcha sweet at a tea house. Return to your accommodation early to be well rested.

Day 2 – Arashiyama & Takao: Nature and Hidden Temples

Morning

- **Arashiyama Bamboo Grove** – Arrive before 8 am to experience the bamboo grove with minimal crowds. After walking through, detour to **Okusaga**, a quieter area behind the main sights. Historic teahouses like **Tsutaya** and **Hiranoya** have served sweetfish dishes for over 400 years ⁸.
- **Gio-ji Temple** – Tucked away in the hills of Arashiyama, Gio-ji has a tiny thatched-roof hall overlooking a moss-covered grotto ⁹. The moss garden invites contemplation, and few visitors stray here because it's off the main path ¹⁰.
- **Otagi Nenbutsu-ji** (optional) – A further walk or short bus ride leads to this temple with 1,200 whimsical rakan statues carved by worshippers. Each statue has a unique expression ¹¹. The temple is remote and admission is modest; the lack of crowds makes it ideal for quiet reflection ¹².

Lunch

- **Local river fish** – Have lunch in Arashiyama or along the Kiyotaki River. Restaurants in Okusaga specialise in ayu (sweetfish) grilled over charcoal and seasonal mountain vegetables.

Afternoon

- **Takao Mountain Temples** – Travel about 30 minutes by bus to the **Takao** area, a mountain hamlet known for cedars and ancient temples ¹³.
- **Jingo-ji Temple** – Founded in 781, this Shingon temple lets visitors throw clay discs into the valley to symbolically rid themselves of bad karma ¹⁴. It houses statues and paintings from the Heian and Kamakura periods ¹⁴.
- **Kosan-ji Temple** – A cedar-lined path leads to this temple with a veranda overlooking the Kiyotaki River valley ¹⁵. It also holds Japan's oldest tea field and the humorous *Choju Giga* animal scrolls ¹⁵.
- **Saimyo-ji** – Often empty, this third temple in Takao features a grotto with a small waterfall ¹⁶.
- **Kawadoko dining** – In summer, Takao restaurants build riverside platforms (kawadoko) where diners sit above the cool river. Reservations are recommended as space is limited ¹³. It's a memorable way to enjoy seasonal dishes and sake.

Evening

- Return to Kyoto city. If you're not too tired, stroll along the **Kamogawa** riverbank where locals gather at dusk.

Day 3 – Ohara & Fushimi: Rural Tranquility and Sake Culture

Morning

- **Ohara village** – Take the bus from Kyoto Station to the rural valley of **Ohara**, north of the city. The area is known for its misty mountains and ancient temples ¹⁷ .
- **Sanzen-in Temple** – The main attraction, Sanzen-in's moss garden features ponds, small Jizo statues and hillside rocks. The temple houses a golden Amida Buddha and offers quiet walking paths ¹⁸ .
- **Ruriko-in** – If open (this temple has limited opening periods), its traditional hall overlooks a brilliant moss and maple garden ¹⁹ .
- **Hot springs** – Ohara has small public hot springs. A foot bath near Sanzen-in is a pleasant treat after walking.

Lunch

- **Country meal in Ohara** – Eat a simple meal featuring **yuba** (tofu skin) simmered in broth ²⁰ , along with **Kyoto vegetables** like Shogoin daikon and Kujo leeks ²¹ . Pickles such as *senmaizuke* or *suguki* often accompany lunch ²² .

Afternoon

- **Fushimi Sake District** – Return to Kyoto and take the train to **Fushimi**. The district lies along an old river port between Kyoto and Osaka, is famed for its high-quality groundwater and hosts over twenty breweries ²³ .
- **Gekkeikan Okura Sake Museum** – Housed in a historic brewery, this museum explains Fushimi's sake history and brewing techniques. Visitors can tour the facilities and taste sake made with underground water ²⁴ . Tasting is part of the admission fee ²⁵ .
- **Stroll the white-walled brewery district** – Walk along the willow-lined Horikawa River, popping into sake shops and small izakaya. Fushimi's shopping streets and restaurants create a pleasant townscape ²³ .
- **Fushimi Inari Taisha** – End the day by climbing the trail of 5,000 vermilion torii gates at **Fushimi Inari**. Dedicated to the god of rice and sake, the shrine's path winds up Mount Inari and becomes ethereal as the light fades ²⁶ . Fox statues dot the route; they are messengers of Inari and symbolize harvests ²⁶ . Walking even part of the loop offers a meditative experience away from daytime crowds.

Dinner

- **Yakitori and sake** – Enjoy dinner at a Fushimi izakaya. Pair grilled skewers with light, locally brewed sake; Fushimi's soft water produces sake that is smooth and slightly sweet ²⁷ .

Additional Tips

- **Slow pace** – Limit each day to a handful of sights clustered by area. Kyoto's buses and subways are efficient, but travel can still be slow during peak times. Building in extra time lets you linger at gardens and temples.
- **Accommodation** – Consider staying near **Gion**, **Northern Higashiyama** or **Nijo** for easy access to the proposed areas. Alternatively, a **ryokan** in **Arashiyama** provides a quieter base.
- **Respectful travel** – Kyoto's attractions are often adjacent to residential areas. Follow local rules: avoid eating while walking through **Nishiki Market** (shopkeepers request that food be eaten at the shop or taken home ²⁸) and keep noise down in temples and on streets.
- **Seasonal preparations** – June is the rainy season. Carry an umbrella and lightweight waterproof footwear. Rain intensifies the moss and greenery, making gardens like Sanzen-in and Gio-ji especially beautiful.

Concluding Thoughts

This three-day itinerary is designed to help you savour Kyoto's beauty without feeling rushed. By combining well-known temples with lesser-visited sanctuaries and pairing them with local culinary experiences, you'll experience both the grandeur and the quiet soul of the city. Feel free to adjust the schedule based on your energy levels and interests; the suggestions are meant to inspire a journey that is as restful and enriching as you need.

1 Honen-in Temple
<https://www.insidekyoto.com/honen-in-temple-northern-higashiyama>

2 Shisen-do Temple Kyoto
<https://www.insidekyoto.com/shisen-do-temple-northern-higashiyama>

3 10 16 Kyoto's Hidden Gems
<https://www.insidekyoto.com/kyoto-secret-spots>

4 5 7 20 21 22 27 Food & Drink | Kyoto Travel
<https://kyoto.travel/en/food-and-drink/>

6 Kiyomizu-dera Temple | Kyoto Travel
<https://kyoto.travel/en/destinations/kiyomizudera-temple/>

8 Saga & Arashiyama | Kyoto Travel
<https://kyoto.travel/en/areas/saga-arashiyama/>

9 Gio-ji Temple Arashiyama
<https://www.insidekyoto.com/gio-ji-temple>

11 12 Otagi Nenbutsu-ji Temple - Inside Kyoto
<https://www.insidekyoto.com/otagi-nenbutsu-ji-temple>

13 Takao | Kyoto Travel
<https://kyoto.travel/en/areas/takao/>

14 Jingo-ji Temple | Kyoto Travel
<https://kyoto.travel/en/destinations/jingoji-temple/>

15 Kosan-ji Temple | Kyoto Travel

<https://kyoto.travel/en/destinations/kosanji-temple/>

17 Ohara | Kyoto Travel

<https://kyoto.travel/en/areas/ohara/>

18 Sanzen-in Temple | Kyoto Travel

<https://kyoto.travel/en/destinations/sanzenin-temple/>

19 Ruriko-in Temple | Kyoto Travel

<https://kyoto.travel/en/destinations/ruriko-in-temple/>

23 Fushimi | Kyoto Travel

<https://kyoto.travel/en/areas/fushimi/>

24 25 Gekkeikan Okura Sake Museum | GEKKEIKAN

<https://www.gekkeikan.com/museum/>

26 Fushimi Inari Taisha Shrine | Kyoto Travel

<https://kyoto.travel/en/destinations/fushimi-inaritaisha-shrine/>

28 Kyoto Nishiki Food Market | Kyoto Travel

<https://kyoto.travel/en/destinations/kyoto-nishiki-food-market/>